

MEET THE SPEAKER

Kirk Charlton

Artist, Educator, and Founder of Art Inside Out

From a prison cell to a national program for healing. Kirk Charlton turned his own experience with incarceration and recovery into a method that has helped thousands of people rediscover their dignity, one drawing at a time.

His Story

Kirk Charlton is an artist and educator whose life took him through incarceration and recovery before it took him into the work he was meant to do. Rather than leave that chapter behind, he built something out of it. He learned firsthand that creativity can reach people in moments when nothing else can, and that a pencil and a piece of paper can open a door that lectures, programs, and good intentions often cannot.

That insight became Art Inside Out (AIO), a trauma-informed creative program now running in correctional facilities, recovery and reentry programs, shelters, behavioral health settings, and senior care across the country, including here in Clermont County. Kirk's approach blends real artistic instruction with honest reflection on patience, self-worth, problem-solving, and starting over. Participants are not asked to be artists. They are simply asked to create, and in the process they become calmer, more focused, and more open to change.

What Art Inside Out Achieves

- **Dramatic recidivism reduction.** Facilities running AIO have seen repeat-offense rates fall significantly, helping people stay out and stay well.
- **Stronger emotional regulation.** The structured rhythm of making art and talking it through helps participants manage stress and mood.
- **Renewed self-worth and connection.** Participants rebuild confidence, respect for one another, and a sense that they still have something to offer.
- **Proven across many settings.** Prisons, treatment centers, shelters, and senior programs all use the same simple, low-cost, high-impact model.

Why You Should Hear Kirk Speak

Kirk does not give a typical presentation. He tells a true story of falling, rebuilding, and finding purpose, and he shows how that story became a program that is changing lives in our own community and beyond. It is honest, hopeful, and unforgettable. You will leave thinking differently about second chances, about creativity, and about the people in our community who are working their way back.

Hear Kirk Charlton at the Exchange Club of Eastern Hills

Friday, June 5, 2026 | 8:00 AM | Anderson Center, 7850 Five Mile Road, Cincinnati, OH 45230

(See pictures on next page of Kirk in action!)

